4.1 Colonial Men and Women

As a girl, can you imagine rights reserved only for boys? As a boy, can you imagine being denied rights because of your family's lack of wealth? That's the way it was in the colonies.

MAIN IDEA Rights and wealth were not evenly distributed across religions, social classes, races, and genders in colonial American society.

RIGHTS AND WEALTH

Between 1720 and 1763, the diverse American population experienced changes in many aspects of their lives. In science, doctors made strides in understanding how diseases spread. People reexamined traditions and laws. The changes spread throughout the colonies.

However, other ideas were resistant to change. Voting was restricted to white men—and to a select group. Only landowning men could vote. But there were exceptions. Men who were Catholic or Jewish were denied the vote based on religion. Servants, slaves, and men without property were also barred. Men with a small amount of land or personal property had to pay to vote.

Although land was plentiful and industry booming, wealth in the colonies was not evenly distributed. This was especially visible in the cities. Fabulously wealthy merchants built mansions and bought coaches with income from trade with other nations or colonies. Less fortunate city dwellers worked for low wages or lacked employment altogether. For instance, seamen and artisans who relied on trade could be out of a job if the demand for goods decreased. In addition, the **burgeoning**, or quickly growing, towns lacked sanitation, putting many people at risk from the spread of disease.

ROLE OF WOMEN

Life was tough for both colonial men and women, but the women had even fewer choices. In rural areas, white wives cooked, cleaned, sewed, reared children, and helped with farm tasks. Many also made candles, soap, and other items to sell or exchange for goods. Most African-American women were enslaved. They worked in the fields, cooked, cleaned, and tended to the slaveholder's family. Only the wives of plantation owners led an easy life. They supervised the household slaves and servants and oversaw meal preparation.

In cities, women cared for their children and the household. Wealthier wives employed servants, and some depended on slaves. Some worked alongside their husbands in shops and businesses. Other women served as **midwives**, helping deliver babies. Poor women often made money by mending, washing, and ironing clothes or providing domestic services. Few women worked outside the home.

Women had few legal rights throughout most of the colonial period. They could not vote. They lost the right to manage their property and earn a living once they married. Many women relied on the church for their social life. Soon, all colonists would be asked to pay more attention to their spiritual lives as well.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What requirements did a person have to meet to be eligible to vote in colonial America?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What details support the idea that wealth was not evenly distributed in colonial American cities?
3. **ANALYZE VISUALS** Which household task may have posed the biggest problem for colonial women? Use the information in the visual to explain your answer.

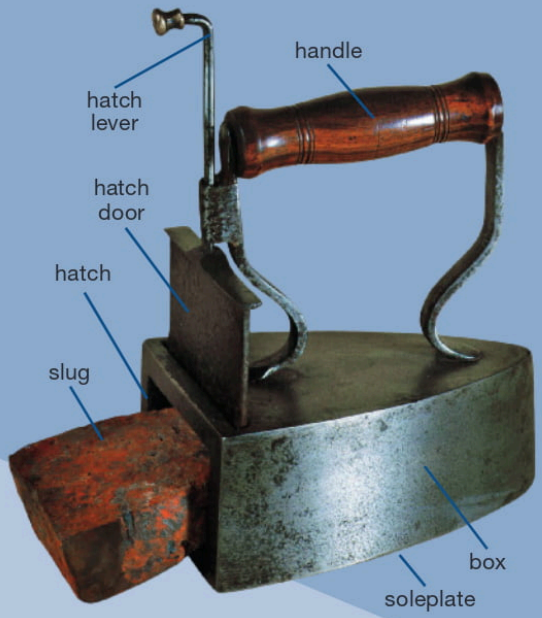
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ALL IN A DAY'S WORK

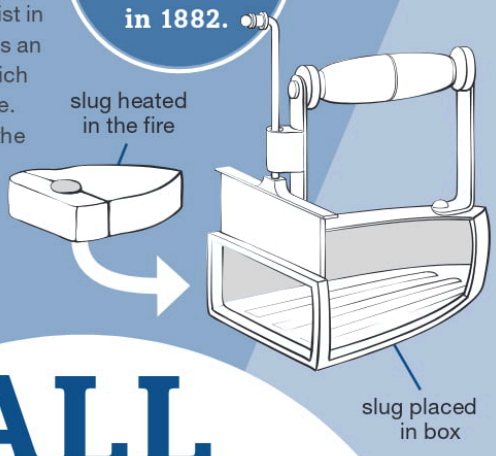
In the days before electricity and grocery stores, colonial women—and, later, the women of early national America—labored to maintain their homes and families. There was cream to churn into butter, and there were fires to stoke and clothes to iron, along with all the other aspects of making sure the family was fed and warm.

BOX IRON

Easy-care fabrics did not exist in colonial times, so ironing was an essential part of laundry, which was hard work at every stage. The box iron had a hatch in the back where the woman inserted a hot metal piece called a slug. One slug sat on the fire until the one in the iron cooled. Then the woman switched them.



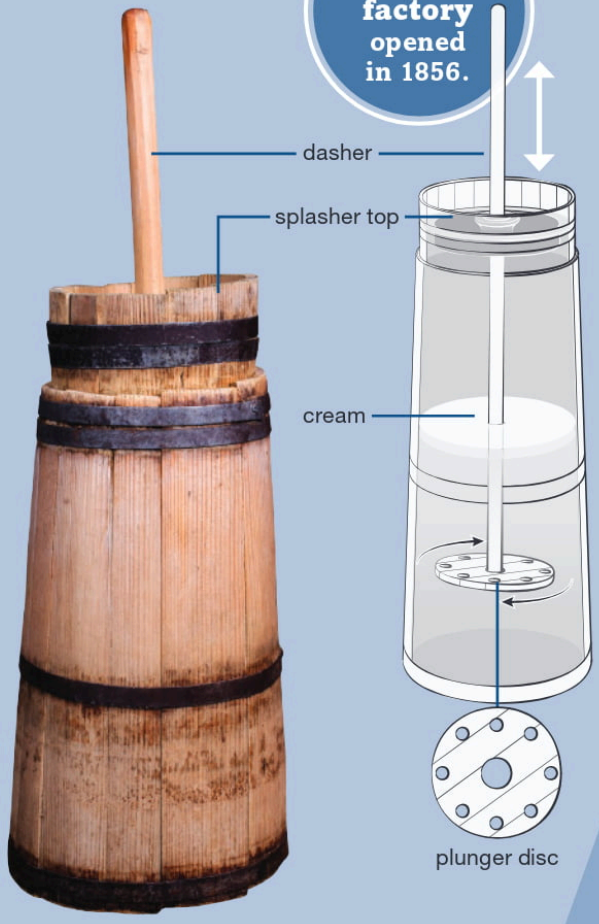
The first electric iron was introduced in 1882.



BUTTER CHURN

For a colonial woman, making butter began with milking a cow. The milk sat in a container until the cream rose to the top. Then the woman skimmed off the cream and put it into a butter churn. She moved the dasher up and down and in circles, churning the cream. After what could be minutes or hours, butter formed, along with buttermilk. The final step was to strain the butter to separate the two.

The first U.S. butter factory opened in 1856.



BED WARMER

Heat from the fireplace of a colonial home did not spread from room to room. If the house couldn't be heated, however, the beds could. A colonial woman filled the pan of a bed warmer with glowing coals and took it from room to room. She moved the pan around under the covers to distribute the heat evenly. Then she went along to the next bed.

The first electric blanket was introduced in 1912.



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